

Pseudogapping(-like construction)

Pseudogapping (PG) refers to a verb gap construction where the inflectional domain remains intact (Sag 1976):

- (1) Mary hasn't **dated** Bill, but she has Δ Harry. (Jayaseelan 1990: 12)

English PG is typically derived by moving the remnant (**Move-R**) plus VP ellipsis (**VPE**) (Sag 1976, Levin 1978, Jayaseelan 1990, Lasnik 1999):

- (2) Mary hasn't **dated** Bill, but she has Harry_i [**dated** t_i].

Chinese has constructions resembling PG:

- (3) a. Zhangsan yinggai **chi** san ge pingguo. *Mandarin*
Zhangsan should eat three CLF apple
Lisi yinggai Δ si ge (pingguo).
Lisi should four CLF apple
'Zhangsan should **eat** three apples.
Lisi should [**eat**] four (apples).' (cf. Wei 2008: 82)
- b. Zoengsaam jinggoi **sik** saam go pinggwō. *Cantonese*
Zoengsaam should eat three CLF apple
Leisei jinggoi Δ sei go (pinggwō).
Leisei should four CLF apple
'Zoengsaam should **eat** three apples.
Leisei should [**eat**] four (apples).'

- We argue that (1) and (3) result from **different derivations**.
- Chinese PG-like construction is derived by **a phonologically null pair-list copula** (following the spirits in Tang 2001 and Lin & Li 2026).

Undergeneration

Verbs with the resultative suffix *-de* (or *-dak*) can be deleted:

- (4) (Zhe zhi wu,) *Mandarin*
this CLF dance
Zhangsan yinggai **tiao-de** hen haokan,
Zhangsan should dance-RES very beautiful
danshi Lisi yinggai Δ hen nankan.
but Lisi should very ugly
'(This dance,) Zhangsan should **dance** very beautifully,
but Lisi should [**dance**] in a very ugly manner.'

- 'Ugly' is interpreted as describing **the event of dancing** instead of the subject as a person.
- This suggests **a true PG-like construction** rather than a simple subject and predicate combination.
- In a movement plus deletion analysis, the second clause would be derived by **moving the resultative complement** and eliding the VP.
- Yet, when the verb is not deleted, we observe the **immobility** of the resultative complement to a preverbal position (5).

- (5) *Zhangsan yinggai [hen haokan]_i tiao-de t_i. *Mandarin*
Zhangsan should very beautiful dance-RES
Intended: 'Zhangsan should dance very beautifully.'

A movement plus deletion analysis therefore undergenerates.

Overgeneration

ADJUNCT EXCLUSION

English VPE and PG omit adjuncts:

- (6) a. Mary hasn't **secretly dated** Bill, but Sue has [**secretly dated** Bill],
#though not secretly.
b. Mary hasn't **secretly dated** Bill, but she has [**secretly dated**] Ben,
#though not secretly. (Jayaseelan 1990: 64, adapted)

This property is shared by Chinese VPE:

- (7) Zhangsan yinggai **manman chi** san ge pingguo,
Zhangsan should slowly eat three CLF apple
danshi Lisi_i bu yinggai Δ . (Ta_i yinggai kuai yi dian.)
but Lisi not should 3SG should fast one bit
'Zhangsan should **slowly eat three apples**,
but Lisi_i shouldn't [**slowly eat three apples**]. (He_i should eat faster.)'

However, it is not shared by Chinese PG-like construction:

- (8) Zhangsan yinggai **manman chi** san ge pingguo,
Zhangsan should slowly eat three CLF apple
danshi Lisi_i bu yinggai Δ san ge.
but Lisi not should three CLF
(#Ta_i yinggai kuai yi dian.)
3SG should fast one bit
'Zhangsan should **slowly eat** three apples,
but Lisi_i should not [(*)**slowly eat**] three. (#He_i should eat faster.)'

LACK OF FULL CONTRASTIVENESS

English PG requires a full contrast conveyed by the remnant:

- (9) a. John should eat three apples, but Mary shouldn't Δ four oranges.
b. # John should eat three apples, but Mary shouldn't Δ four apples.
c. * John should eat three apples, but Mary shouldn't Δ three apples.

As in (8), this contrast is not required in Chinese.

LICENSING HEADS

The diagnostic in (6–7) gives us the following VPE-licensing heads in Chinese (Lee & Pan 2024):

	Raising modal	Preverbal aspect	Control verb
VPE	✓	✓	✓
Move-R	✓	✗	✓
PG-like construction	✓	✗	✗

Table 1. Chinese VPE-licensing heads

- Among Chinese VPE-licensing heads, **only raising modals** license PG-like constructions.
- In a movement plus deletion analysis, this is not surprising for **preverbal aspects**, which disallow Move-R.
- However, it *is* surprising for **control verbs**, which *do* allow Move-R.

A movement plus deletion analysis therefore overgenerates.

Phonologically null pair-list copula

RAISING-CONTROL CONTRAST

- A phonologically null copula naturally captures the observations summarized in table 1, with PG-like examples repeated in (10).
- Raising modals contrast with control verbs and preverbal aspects in whether they can be immediately followed by a copula (11).

- (10) *PG-like construction: ✓Raising modal but ✗control verb*
- a. See (3a) for *yinggai* 'should' allowing PG-like construction.
- b. Zhangsan neng/xiang/you **chi** san ge pingguo.
Zhangsan can want PFV eat three CLF apple
(*Lisi neng/xiang/you Δ si ge (pingguo).)
Lisi can want PFV four CLF apple
'Zhangsan can **eat**/wants to **eat/ate** three apples.
(*Lisi can/wants to/did [**eat**] four (apples).)

- (11) *Copula: Also ✓raising modal but ✗control verb*
- a. Zhangsan yinggai shi (chi) san ge pingguo.
Zhangsan should COP eat three CLF apple
'Zhangsan should eat three apples.'
- b. *Zhangsan neng/xiang/you shi (chi) san ge pingguo.
Zhangsan can want PFV COP eat three CLF apple
Intended: 'Zhangsan can eat/wants to eat/ate three apples.'

PAIR-LIST COPULA

We suggest a connection with Lin & Li's (2026) pair-list copula:

- (12) a. Na ge laoshi jiao na men ke?
which CLF teacher teach which CLF class
'Which teacher teaches which class?'
- b. Zhang laoshi shi Yingwen. Li laoshi shi shuxue.
Zhang teacher COP English Li teacher COP math
'Teacher Zhang teaches English. Teacher Li teaches Math.'
(Lin & Li 2026: 10–11)

Concluding remarks

- Chinese PG-like constructions $\neq$ English PG.
- Instead, Chinese PG-like constructions are derived by phonologically null pair-list copulae.

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